



Keys, Danielle Collins, and Clara Tauson. These and other heavy hitters will prevent Swiatek from reaching a Major final.

- The most difficult woman to predict is gifted but volatile 18-year-old Russian **Mirra Andreieva**. At her marvellous, versatile best, Andreieva won Dubai and Indian Wells, taking down Sabalenka, Swiatek (twice), Rybakina (twice), Clara Tauson (twice), and Marketa Vondrousova. At her moody, erratic worst, Andreieva lost eight times in the first or second round. The No. 9 could make her first Grand Slam final, but she may not be mature enough to win a Major this year. Whatever happens, she is sure to provide quirky and witty quotes, such as 'I would like to thank me,' during her Dubai victory speech. 'I know what I have been dealing with, and I just want to thank me for always believing in me.'

- **Naomi Osaka's (above)** comeback, which picked up some steam in 2025, will lose momentum. An intimidating power game carried Osaka to four Grand Slam singles titles from the 2018 US Open to the 2021 Australian Open. Tellingly, the average speed of her first serve — the linchpin of her offence — drastically decreased from 181 km/h (112.5 mph) in 2022 to 167 km/h (103.8 mph) in 2025. Osaka won't reach a Major semifinal or crack the top 10.

- Among the newcomers, **Tiantsoa Rakotomanga Rajaonah** will be the best bet on the WTA Tour. The 20-year-old Frenchwoman born in Madagascar features a powerful left-handed offence and speedy defence. Meanwhile, on the men's side, watch out for Spain's Rafael Jodar, Belgium's Alexander Blockx, and Norway's Nicolai Budkov Kjær.



Off-beat

Coaches and teaching pros will emphasise the split step more than ever.

Knowledgeable TV tennis analysts like Jim Courier and Mark Petchey will describe how the split step should be executed and which world-class players do it most efficiently to gain precious split seconds. The art of sliding — not just on clay but also on hard courts — will also be analysed more rigorously and expertly than ever.

Height and might will make right more than ever in pro tennis.

No man under 6 ft and no woman under 5 ft 9 in will reach a Major final, and the average height of Masters 1000 champions will be 6 ft 3 in and 5 ft 10 in, respectively.

The ATP and WTA Tours will set records for total tie-breaks and for match tie-breaks.

Service holds will increase because of greater parity among the top 100 players and the rise in power and precision of first serves and first shots after the return. As a result, players at every level will practise seven-point and ten-point tie-breaks more than ever.

The ATP, WTA, World Tennis, and the Grand Slam Committee will come to their collective senses with several badly needed policy and rule reforms.

They'll downsize the much-criticised, bloated 12-day Masters 1000 events to 10 days, sharply reduce the number of late-night matches finishing after 2 am by starting evening sessions at 6 pm (instead of 7 pm), restore electronic technology for service lets and expand its use to call double bounces, reinstate the legitimate mixed doubles event at the U.S. Open, and increase the men's off-season from an absurdly short six weeks to eight.

On December 7, 2015, air pollution in Beijing reached 40 times the limit considered safe by the World Health Organization.

A decade later, our planet has become dirtier, hotter, and drier — more dangerous and less habitable. In 2026, extreme weather events will force the cancellation of a tournament in Asia and suspend play for multiple days at several more tournaments worldwide. Even with the new ATP rule allowing ten-minute breaks during best-of-three-sets singles matches to protect players during extreme heat and humidity, a record number of debilitated players will retire during matches.

Lamentably, wars will impact professional and amateur tennis in unforeseen ways.

As of October 2025, 40 countries were at war, according to the World Population Review. Most involved terrorist insurgencies or civil wars, such as the armed conflict that posed a major threat to the 2025 ATP Challenger event staged in Brazzaville, the capital of Congo.

Artificial intelligence is likely to change the tennis world in 2026.

Questions abound. For starters, which areas will AI impact? And will AI benefit or harm tennis?

The Chinese humanoid robot Walker S2 has wildly improved on the Tesla Optimus movements and can hit 'perfect strokes' against humans.

Walker S2 will be used as a reliable practice partner and teaching aid. As Alex Hirschi, aka Supercar Blondie, said in an article on her website: 'It has mastered the art of running and can marathon with unlimited stamina — or until its battery dies'. Check it out in a new video posted by its creator, UBTECH.